



HIGH COURT OF MADRAS

Permanent Secretariat | Senior Advocate Designation
High Court Buildings, Chennai - 600 104, Tamil Nadu

DETAILED PROJECT REPORT

Portal for Designation of Senior Advocates

*An online system for the Application-cum-Consent Letter under the
Rules for Designation of Senior Advocates, 2026*

Document type	Detailed Project Report (abridged)
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This report describes the as-built portal, its modules, technology, security and operations.

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1. Project at a glance

Project title	Portal for Designation of Senior Advocates
Sponsoring authority	High Court of Madras
Implementing unit	Permanent Secretariat, Senior Advocate Designation
Legal basis	Rules for Designation of Senior Advocates, 2026
Nature	Web-based e-governance application (as-built)
Primary users	Advocates (applicants) and High Court staff (admin / reviewer / approver)
Core output	Online Application-cum-Consent Letter (proforma Sl. No. 1-24) with Formats L-1 to L-4
Application number	MHC/SSA/{year}/{serial} (example: MHC/SSA/2026/0001)
Public contact	hcmadras.tn.gov.in 044-2530 1330 High Court Buildings, Chennai - 600 104
Website	https://www.hcmadras.tn.gov.in/

This abridged DPR is intended for administrative approval, security review, hosting and day-to-day operation. It is not a substitute for the Approved Rules or for official notifications issued by the High Court. In case of any conflict, the Rules and notifications prevail.

2. Introduction and background

Designation as Senior Advocate is a statutory and institutional process governed by the Approved Rules of the High Court of Madras. Candidates must furnish a complete Application-cum-Consent Letter covering personal particulars, enrolment and practice, reported and unreported judgments, pro bono and amicus work, academic contribution, declarations and supporting documents.

The Portal for Designation of Senior Advocates is the official online channel for this process. It replaces unstructured paper collection with a guided, audited workflow: advocates register with enrolment particulars, complete a seven-step form aligned to the official proforma, upload prescribed files, receive a unique application number, download a print-ready PDF, and file a paper book at the Permanent Secretariat. Staff classify applications against each notified cycle and maintain a full audit trail.

3. Need for the portal

A designation cycle involves a large volume of structured data (Formats L-1 to L-4), strict last dates, and scrutiny by the Permanent Secretariat. Manual-only filing creates risk of incomplete proforma, ineligible late applications, loss of documents, and weak traceability. An online portal is required to:

- Capture every field of the official proforma (Sl. No. 1-24) with draft-save and validation.
- Enforce the notified application window and one-application-per-cycle rule.
- Accept only prescribed file types and sizes (photograph, signature, enrolment certificate, Formats L-1 to L-4).
- Issue a unique application number and a print-ready form for the paper book.
- Give staff a single register for listing, wait-listing and deferral, with Excel export and audit logs.
- Notify advocates of registration, email verification, password reset and submission by email and SMS.
- Publish official notifications and the Rules, 2026 PDF from the same portal.

4. Objectives

No.	Objective	Success measure
1	Enable complete online filing of the Application-cum-Consent Letter.	All mandatory fields and uploads captured before submit.
2	Align the form with Rules, 2026 and notified cycles.	Windows, age-as-on date and cycle year taken from the official notification.
3	Protect applicant data and the integrity of the process.	HTTPS, role-based access, CAPTCHA, lockout, file checks, audit log.
4	Support Secretariat review and classification.	Dashboard counts; Select Listed / Wait Listed / Deferred List; PDF and Excel.
5	Meet GIGW-oriented publication duties.	Privacy, terms, copyright, hyperlinking, disclaimer and help pages.

5. Scope of work

5.1 In scope

Public pages (login, register, instructions, Rules PDF, notifications); advocate account (email verification, password reset, account unlock, change password); seven-step application with Formats L-1 to L-4; secure file store; generated application PDF; staff dashboard and classification; designation notifications (cycle, dates, document); master data (qualifications, courts, tribunals, nature of practice, field of law); email and SMS configuration and templates; audit log; GIGW policy pages.

5.2 Out of scope

The portal does not decide designation. It does not replace the Permanent Committee / Full Court process, does not accept the physical paper book, and does not publish a public list of designated Senior Advocates. Payment gateway, video conferencing, and case-law search are not part of this system. Eligibility under the Rules remains a matter for the competent authority, not for automated scoring.

5.3 Physical filing that remains

After online submission the advocate must still file, at the Permanent Secretariat: (i) one print-out of the application with attachments as a tagged and indexed paper book; and (ii) one recent passport-size colour photograph with the name written on the reverse. Late applications beyond the notified last date are not entertained.

6. Users and application process

6.1 Roles

Role	Who	Principal functions
Applicant	Advocate enrolled with a Bar Council	Register, verify email, fill steps 1-7, upload documents, submit, download PDF, track status.
Admin	Nominated officers of the High Court	Full staff access: classify applications, notifications, masters, email/SMS, audit, Excel export.
Reviewer / Approver	Staff roles reserved in the system	Access to the staff area. Classification is presently restricted to the Admin role.

6.2 Advocate journey

Step	Action	Notes
1. Register	Create account. Name must match the enrolment certificate (no abbreviated name).	Enrolment lookup against the advocate database; CAPTCHA and rate limit.
2. Verify	Confirm email. Unlock account if locked after failed logins.	Single-use links. Password reset valid for one hour.
3. Instructions	Read instructions and accept before the form is created.	Application period is taken from the active official notification.
4. Fill form	Seven steps; drafts may be saved and resumed.	See section 7.1. One application per designation cycle.
5. Submit	Declarations, uploads, final acknowledgement.	Error after submit cannot be rectified by the applicant as of right.
6. Paper book	Print PDF and file at the Permanent Secretariat.	Photograph on reverse of physical copy as instructed.
7. Track	View status from the advocate dashboard.	Submitted / Select Listed / Wait Listed / Deferred List.

6.3 Status pipeline (staff)

Operational classification used by the Secretariat is: Submitted, Select Listed, Wait Listed and Deferred List. Draft applications remain with the advocate until submit. Returned-for-correction is retained in the data model for possible future use. Status changes are recorded; bulk update is available to Admin.

7. Functional modules

7.1 Seven-step application (proforma Sl. No. 1-24)

Step	Title	Content
1	Personal details	Title, full name, date of birth, age (Y/M/D as on notification date), addresses, phone, email, qualifications, age proof and education uploads.
2	Enrolment and practice	Enrolment number and date, Bar Council, practice period, income, Bar Association, earlier applications to MHC / other courts.
3	Judgments (L-1 / L-2)	Reported and unreported matters argued as lead / assisting counsel before SC, High Courts and District / Trial Courts, with Format PDFs.
4	Pro bono and academic	Pro bono (L-3(i)), amicus curiae (L-3(ii)), articles, books, teaching and guest lectures (L-4).
5	Practice domain	Courts and tribunals practised, nature of practice, field of law, cumulative experience (master lists with 'Others').
6	Declarations	FIR, criminal cases, Bar Council proceedings, general health, other information, declaration of truth.
7	Uploads and submit	Photograph, signature, enrolment certificate, Format PDFs; final acknowledgement; application number allotted.

7.2 Document specifications

Document	Format	Size
Passport photograph	JPG / JPEG	20-200 KB
Signature	JPG / JPEG	20-200 KB
Enrolment certificate, age proof, educational qualifications	PDF	Up to 5 MB
Formats L-1, L-2, L-3(i), L-3(ii), L-4	PDF	Up to 5 MB each

Images are re-encoded to strip polyglot payloads. PDFs are checked by magic bytes and scanned for embedded script. Files are stored under writable/uploads (outside the public web root) and served only to authenticated users with access rights.

7.3 Staff modules

Module	Purpose
Dashboard	Counts of submitted / listed / wait-listed / deferred applications and recent filings.
Applications	Search, view full form and attachments, download PDF, classify status, bulk update, Excel export.
Notifications	Official designation notifications: number, date, title, PDF, application window and edit window.
Masters	Qualifications, courts, tribunals, nature of practice, field of law (with seed defaults).
Email / SMS settings	SMTP and SMS gateway configuration with test send.
Notification templates	Event templates for registration, verification, reset, submission and related messages.
Audit	Immutable-style activity log including failed login attempts.

7.4 Public information

Instructions for advocates, the Rules for Designation of Senior Advocates, 2026 (view and download), published notification PDFs, and GIGW policy pages (privacy, terms, copyright, hyperlinking, disclaimer, help) are available without login. Last-updated date is displayed as required for government websites.

8. Technical architecture

The portal is a three-tier web application. The browser talks only to the HTTPS front end. The application server (CodeIgniter 4) holds business rules, sessions and file validation. PostgreSQL holds structured data. Generated PDFs and uploaded files sit on disk outside the document root.

Advocates / public portal

Register (enrolment lookup) | 7-step application | track status | PDF

Permanent Secretariat staff

Dashboard | classification | notifications | masters | audit | Excel

Application layer / CodeIgniter 4

Auth, CSRF, CAPTCHA, uploads, Dompdf, SMTP, SMS gateway

Data & hosting

PostgreSQL | TLS / HTTPS | uploads in writable/ (not public) | WAF

Figure 1. Logical layers of the portal.

Layer	Choice	Remarks
Language / framework	PHP 8.1.2+ CodeIgniter 4	MVC; PHP 8.2+ recommended.
Database	PostgreSQL	UTF-8; migrations and seeders under version control.
Web / TLS	Apache or Nginx with HTTPS	ForceHTTPS filter; HSTS to be enabled at the reverse proxy.
PDF	Dompdf	Application-cum-Consent Letter print-out.
Email	SMTP (admin-configured)	Verification, reset, unlock, submission notices.
SMS	HTTP gateway or file log	Same events; fallback to log if gateway fails.
Front end	HTML, CSS, JavaScript (Bootstrap-based institutional UI)	Responsive layout; skip-to-content and contrast support.
WAF	ModSecurity with extra SSA rules	Supplemented by an application input-threat filter.

8.1 Indicative hosting profile

Production should run on the State Data Centre, NIC cloud, or an equivalent government-approved host with daily backup, TLS certificate, WAF and restricted SSH. Suggested starting size: 2 vCPU, 4-8 GB RAM, 80 GB disk, with growth for uploads during a live cycle. The web root must point only to the public/ directory. PHP extensions required include intl, mbstring, json and the PostgreSQL driver. Staging should mirror production for security testing.

9. Security, audit and compliance

Control	Implementation
Transport	HTTPS enforced at application level; production must terminate TLS with a valid certificate.
Authentication	Password accounts; CAPTCHA on login/register; 5 failed attempts per email / 20 per IP in 15 minutes; persisted account lock with email unlock.
Authorisation	Role filter on routes (applicant vs admin/reviewer/approver). File URLs are not public.
Session / CSRF	Server sessions; CSRF token on all state-changing requests; no-store headers on application forms.

Control	Implementation
Input	Parameterised queries; InvalidChars; application filter for PHP tags and PostgreSQL injection patterns.
Uploads	Type, MIME, size, magic-byte and script checks; JPEG re-encode; storage outside web root.
Audit	Status history and audit_logs including failed logins; notification_logs for email/SMS.
Privacy	Data used only for designation processing. Not sold. Access limited by role.
GIGW	Policy pages, last-updated date, organisational footer, content ownership line.

Before public go-live, a vulnerability assessment and penetration test (VAPT) by a CERT-In empanelled auditor should be completed and high/critical findings closed. Periodic re-audit should follow the High Court's IT security calendar. Security incidents are to be reported to the Registrar (IT-cum-Statistics) and handled per CERT-In directions.

10. Implementation, hosting and support

10.1 As-built status

The software described in this DPR is already developed and in use as an internal / pre-production portal (registration, multi-step application, staff classification, notifications, masters, email/SMS, audit). Remaining institutional tasks are hosting hardening, VAPT, production DNS and TLS, SMS gateway credentials, advocate-database load, staff training and issue of the live notification.

10.2 Suggested go-live sequence

Phase	Activity	Owner
A	Production host, TLS, WAF, backups, DNS.	IT wing / SDC
B	Load advocate enrolment data; create staff users; SMTP and SMS live test.	Permanent Secretariat + IT
C	VAPT and closure of findings; GIGW content sign-off.	IT + Registrar (IT-cum-Statistics)
D	Staff rehearsal on a closed cycle; print-path check of PDF and paper book.	Permanent Secretariat
E	Publish official notification; open application window; helpdesk during the cycle.	High Court
F	After last date: freeze window, classify, archive, AMC.	Permanent Secretariat + IT

10.3 Training and helpdesk

One half-day session for Secretariat staff (dashboard, search, PDF, status, notifications, Excel) and a short advocate FAQ on the Instructions page are sufficient. Help during the open window should be through the published email and 044-2530 1330, with official correspondence to the Registrar (Administration) where required.

10.4 Backup and continuity

Database and upload directory are to be backed up daily during an open cycle and retained per judicial record-retention norms. In a prolonged outage, the competent authority may notify an alternate channel (including physical filing at the Permanent Secretariat). The official Rules and notifications remain the source of truth if the portal is unavailable.

11. Indicative cost and schedule

Figures below are indicative for administrative planning. They do not constitute a quotation. Actual cost will follow NIC / SDC / GEM rates, existing High Court licences, and the outcome of VAPT. Application development is treated as completed (as-built).

Cost head	Basis	Indicative (Rs. lakh)
Application software (as-built)	Already developed; no fresh build cost in this DPR	Nil (sunk)
Production hosting (12 months)	SDC / NIC / approved cloud, TLS, backups	1.50 - 3.00
VAPT (CERT-In empanelled)	One cycle before go-live; re-test of fixes	1.00 - 2.00

Cost head	Basis	Indicative (Rs. lakh)
SMS transactional pack	As per NIC / TRAI-compliant gateway	0.20 - 0.50
Training, FAQ, go-live support	Staff rehearsal + helpdesk during first cycle	0.25 - 0.50
Annual maintenance (Year 1)	Bug-fix, cycle configuration, minor change requests (~15-20%)	1.50 - 2.50
Contingency (10%)	Unforeseen hosting or audit work	0.45 - 0.85
Indicative Year-1 total	Excluding sunk development	4.90 - 9.35

Schedule: Phases A-C can run in parallel over 3-4 weeks after host allocation. Phase D (rehearsal) needs about one week. Phase E is gated by the official notification. A designation cycle typically remains open only for the window printed on that notification.

12. Benefits, risks and recommendation

12.1 Benefits

Stakeholder	Benefit
Advocates	Guided form, draft save, clear document rules, unique number, printable PDF, status visibility.
Permanent Secretariat	Complete digital register, cycle-wise window, bulk classification, Excel, audit trail.
High Court	Process aligned to Rules, 2026; reduced incomplete filings; GIGW-oriented public pages.
Record-keeping	Application PDF, uploads and status history retained under institutional control.

12.2 Principal risks and mitigation

Risk	Mitigation
Rush of filings near the last date	Capacity test; applicants advised to submit early; window includes date and time.
Incorrect or incomplete data	Step validation; instruction acknowledgement; paper-book scrutiny at Secretariat.
Malicious upload or injection	File re-encode and PDF checks; WAF; input-threat filter; parameterised SQL.
Account takeover	CAPTCHA, logout, email unlock, short-lived reset tokens.
Hosting outage during the window	Backups; SDC SLA; authority may notify an alternate filing channel.
Conflict with Rules / notification	Portal content yields to the official Rules and High Court notifications.

12.3 Recommendation

It is recommended that the High Court of Madras adopt this as-built portal as the official online channel for the Designation of Senior Advocates, subject to: (i) production hosting on an approved government facility with TLS and backup; (ii) closure of VAPT findings; (iii) live SMTP and SMS; (iv) loaded enrolment master; and (v) issue of the designation notification that opens the application window. The Permanent Secretariat should continue to receive the physical paper book as prescribed in the instructions.

Document control

Title	Detailed Project Report -- Portal for Designation of Senior Advocates
Version	1.0 (abridged, under 10 pages)
Date	August 2026
Prepared for	High Court of Madras -- Permanent Secretariat
Web Information Manager	The Registrar (IT-cum-Statistics)
Next review	After first live designation cycle, or on amendment of the Rules